

Property Investment Purchase Checklist — South Australia

Due diligence for buying an investment property, including SA's distinctive trust land tax treatment.

Correct as at July 2026. General information only — not financial, tax or legal advice. Engage a qualified accountant, mortgage broker, and conveyancer before purchasing.

Section 1 — Structuring the Purchase

- ☐ ☐ **Decide on ownership structure before you buy** — individual, joint, trust, or company each carry different land tax and asset-protection implications, and this decision is difficult to unwind after settlement.
- ☐ ☐ **Understand South Australia's land tax thresholds.** The general threshold for individuals is approximately **\$833,000**, but land held in a **trust** faces a dramatically lower threshold of just **\$25,000**.
- ☐ ☐ **Understand why this matters so much in SA specifically.** A trust-held \$1 million property costs roughly **\$5,000/year** in land tax versus around **\$835/year** for the same property held individually — SA's 2020 land tax redesign made many previously-common trust structures uneconomic almost overnight. Get a written land tax comparison from your accountant before deciding on a trust structure here.
- ☐ ☐ **If you're a foreign entity, budget for the foreign ownership surcharge.** Currently **7%**, applied to the purchase — on a \$600,000 purchase, that's an additional \$42,000, so model this into your feasibility from day one if any part of your buyer or ownership structure involves a foreign entity.
- ☐ ☐ **Note that first home buyer stamp duty relief does not extend to investors** — investors pay standard transfer duty rates on any purchase, with no special first-home-style concession available.
- ☐ ☐ **Get investment-specific finance pre-approval.**

Section 2 — Due Diligence on the Property Itself

- ☐ ☐ **Order a building and pest inspection promptly** — remember, SA's cooling-off period is just 2 clear business days, the shortest in the country, so move fast.
- ☐ ☐ **Review the Form 1 (Vendor's Statement) carefully.**
- ☐ ☐ **If buying a community titled or strata property, review the records thoroughly** — sinking fund health and special levies directly affect your investment returns.
- ☐ ☐ **Research the local rental market specifically** — vacancy rates, comparable rents, and tenant demand for your target Adelaide suburb or regional area, particularly given SA's currently very tight vacancy rates.

Section 3 — Setting Up for Compliance From Day One

- ☐ ☐ **Budget for compliance with the Residential Tenancies Act 1995** as reformed from 1 July 2024 — no-grounds terminations are abolished, pets are permitted subject to reasonable conditions, and evidence requirements for bond claims are stricter than before.
- ☐ ☐ **Decide on self-management vs. a property manager** — given the reform pace since 2024, self-managing landlords need to stay genuinely current with prescribed forms and process requirements.
- ☐ ☐ **Arrange landlord insurance**, separate from standard building insurance.
- ☐ ☐ **Engage a quantity surveyor for a tax depreciation schedule** shortly after settlement — see the separate Tax & Depreciation Checklist in this series.

Section 4 — Understanding the Current Tax Environment

- ☐ ☐ **Be aware Commonwealth CGT settings for investment property are changing**, with reforms affecting the CGT discount generally applying from **1 July 2027** — confirm the finalised current position with your accountant.
- ☐ ☐ **Get advice on purchase and sale timing relative to this changeover** if your investment horizon spans the 2027 transition.

Quick Reference — SA Investment Property Snapshot (July 2026)

ITEM	DETAIL
Land tax threshold (individuals)	~\$833,000
Land tax threshold (trusts)	\$25,000
Foreign ownership surcharge	7% at purchase
First home buyer investor relief	None — investors pay standard transfer duty rates
Cooling-off period	2 clear business days (shortest in Australia)

Land tax and surcharge rates change with state budgets — always confirm current figures with RevenueSA before settling on a purchase strategy.

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